

“The **education** and **empowerment** of **women** throughout the world **cannot fail** to result in a more **caring, tolerant, just,** and **peaceful life** for all.”

AUNG SAN SUU KYI, KEYNOTE ADDRESS TO THE NGO FORUM ON WOMEN, 1995

act, dress, and work to please their future husbands. Similar practices occurred in societies more than a millennium later, and even into the 20th century, upper-class girls in the West were sent to “finishing schools,” where they learned deportment and skills that would help them to enter high society. These schools taught girls social graces, such as how to make polite conversation, and emphasized being “ladylike”; one example was the Institut Alpin Videmanette in Switzerland, where students—including Diana, Princess of Wales, in the 1970s—learned how to cook, ski, make dresses, and speak French.

Academic education

The 18th century saw a blossoming of institutions for girls that had academic curricula. New schools were often established by nuns or female rulers. The oldest girls’ school in the United States, the Ursuline Academy in New Orleans, was founded by Sisters of the Order of Saint Ursuline in 1727, and in 1786, Queen Catherine the Great allowed girls to receive free primary and secondary education in Russia. In the West, women’s participation in higher education dates back to the 11th century; women were permitted to study and teach at the University of Bologna, Italy, from its founding in 1088. In 1237, a woman called Bettisia Gozzadina earned her law degree there, and taught at the institution from 1239. Many universities, however, did not admit women. This problem persisted until the 19th century, when women’s colleges were founded in the US and elsewhere. Mount Holyoke Female Seminary, founded in 1837, is the oldest women’s college still operating for that purpose.

Today, the majority of schools and colleges are coeducational. Yet while studies suggest that girls do better in school than boys, at the highest levels of academia women are still outnumbered by men. Women in academia are also more likely than their male counterparts to be offered temporary or part-time positions, and to be given contracts with a heavy teaching load. On the other end of the spectrum, inequality at the most basic level also persists, especially in developing countries; today, two-thirds of the 750 million illiterate adults in the world are women.



“If you **educate** a **man**, you **educate** an **individual**, but if you **educate** a **woman**, you **educate** a **nation**.”

FANTI PROVERB, AFRICA